Viewing the Commit History

Tuesday, November 25, 2025 10:41 PM

After you have created several commits, or if you have cloned a repository with an existing commit history, you'll probably want to look back to see what has happened.

The most basic and **powerful tool** to do this is the **git log command**. By default it **lists** the **commits** made in that repository in reverse chronological order; that is, the **most recent commits show up first**

git log

```
$ git log
commit 2c3319499dbe9dd51517805e2213643a807a3e60 (HEAD -> main)
Author: sajid ali <sajid.ali@giki.edu.pk>
Date:   Mon Sep 26 03:58:12 2022 +0500

    adding another test file

commit ec0db1f1769c4fa00a51ba6907098d908c786b0c
Author: sajid ali <sajid.ali@giki.edu.pk>
Date:   Mon Sep 26 03:43:29 2022 +0500

    .gitignore file added

commit d8d2dcb7141dc1b48c17312162568df4e8a94a8d
Author: sajid ali <sajid.ali@giki.edu.pk>
Date:   Mon Sep 26 00:54:49 2022 +0500

    added readme file
```

```
$ git log
commit 2c3319499dbe9dd51517805e2213643a807a3e60 (HEAD -> main)
Author: sajid ali <sajid.ali@giki.edu.pk>
Date:   Mon Sep 26 03:58:12 2022 +0500

    adding another test file

commit ec0db1f1769c4fa00a51ba6907098d908c786b0c
Author: sajid ali <sajid.ali@giki.edu.pk>
Date:   Mon Sep 26 03:43:29 2022 +0500

    .gitignore file added

commit d8d2dcb7141dc1b48c17312162568df4e8a94a8d
Author: sajid ali <sajid.ali@giki.edu.pk>
Date:   Mon Sep 26 00:54:49 2022 +0500

    added readme file
```

Common git log options

git log -p

git log -p --stat

git log --pretty=format:"%h - %an, %ar : %s"

Option	Description
`-p`	Show the patch introduced with each commit.
`--stat`	Show statistics for files modified in each commit.
`--shortstat`	Display only the changed/insertions/deletions line from the --stat command.
`--name-only`	Show the list of files modified after the commit information.
`--name-status`	Show the list of files affected with added/modified/deleted information as well.
`--abbrev-commit`	Show only the first few characters of the SHA-1 checksum instead of all 40.
`--relative-date`	Display the date in a relative format (for example, “2 weeks ago”) instead of using the full date format.
`--graph`	Display an ASCII graph of the branch and merge history beside the log output.
`--pretty`	Show commits in an alternate format. Option values include oneline, short, full, fuller, and format (where you specify your own format).
`--oneline`	Shorthand for `--pretty=oneline --abbrev-commit` used together.

Limiting Log Output

git log --since=2.weeks

git log --author='sajid' --since="2022-08-01"

you can specify a specific date like "2008-01-15", or a relative date such as "2 years 1 day 3 minutes ago".

Option	Description
`-<n>`	Show only the last n commits
`--since`, `--after`	Limit the commits to those made after the specified date.
`--until`, `--before`	Limit the commits to those made before the specified date.
`--author`	Only show commits in which the author entry matches the specified string.
`--committer`	Only show commits in which the committer entry matches the specified string.
`--grep`	Only show commits with a commit message containing the string
`-S`	Only show commits adding or removing code matching the string